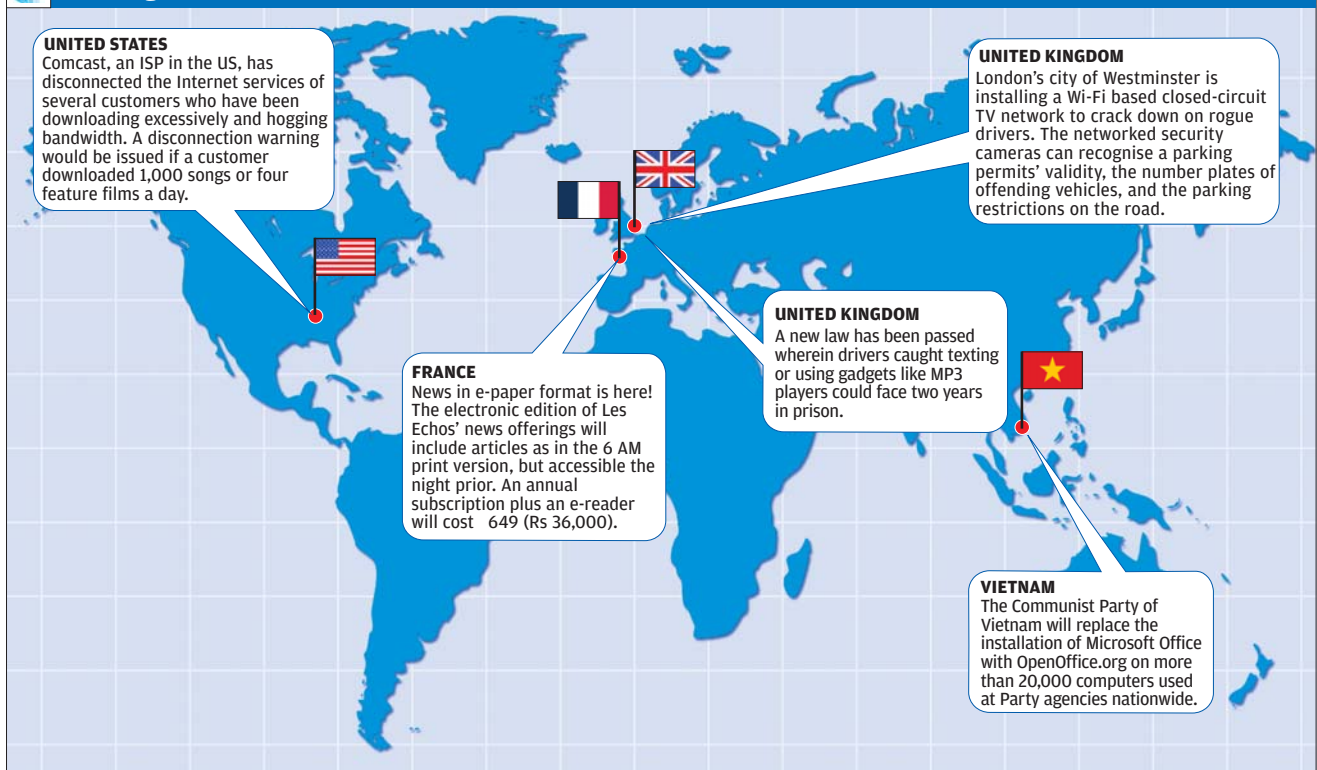


 The Digital World

A Round-up Of Technology News From Across The Globe



engineering application calculations, too, could be offloaded to the GPU. Both AMD and NVIDIA have indeed demonstrated technology to enable this kind of offloading.

Ageia, the other physics company, has its discrete physics cards; reports are that it's struggling with sales of those. And with Intel grabbing Havok, it's not hard to speculate who'll win the physics war. Intel's chips could also become the final destination for all specialised task offloading.

So what does all this mean for us? Well, there are too many variables to consider, too many possibilities to hope for a satisfactory answer. Will integrated graphics become the norm? In fact, will the GPU merge with the CPU? Will competition be stifled, or will it become healthier? Will specialised physics computation in games become de rigeur, powered by Intel? What are NVIDIA and AMD thinking?

All we can guess at is that Intel's one very happy company right now.

USB MOVES UP**Faster Transfers**

“When will the successor to USB 2.0 be out” is something people have been asking for some time now; at the Intel Developer Forum in September, CTO Pat Gelsinger demonstrated USB 3.0 technology. It's still in the prototype stage, but we now know USB 3.0 aims to achieve 5 Gbps—that's 10 times the bandwidth of USB 2.0. Apart from Gelsinger's demonstration, the “SuperSpeed” USB promotions group was announced, which has the agenda of finalising the new specification.

5 Gbps requires fibre optic cabling, but the 3.0 iteration will retain full compatibility with USB 2.0.

Gelsinger expects the final specifications to be done by the first half of 2008, and that USB 3.0 peripherals will appear in 2009 or possibly 2010.

Many details remain unclear. Here's one pressing issue: USB as a protocol has been criticised for relatively high CPU usage. Naturally, with dual-core processors, that became less of a problem, but if we're talking about 5 Gbps, the issue could resurface.

One source talks of a detail no-one else has mentioned: that USB 3.0 will be optimised for low power consumption.

USB 3.0 will go ahead of eSATA, which stands at 3 Gbps, and which is the only device protocol that might challenge it—according to some. Not according to Apple, though.

Watch out for Apple's reaction—they're still partial to FireWire (800 Mbps); a 3.2 Gbps iterations is planned for next year, and they're eyeing 10 Gbps after that.

However, if Apple joins the USB 3.0 consortium—read HP, Microsoft, and more—FireWire might well feature in our *Whatever Happened To* section, which talks about things that were.

ALTER EGOS GALORE**Lying Faces, Prying Into Spaces**

This is one of those “new survey results” stories, but we're talking about it because it poses interesting questions.

It's about social networking (SN) sites, which we spoke about last month. Hackers—in general, evil cyber-people—are stealing data from these sites, making it dangerous to reveal data there. Also making it risky for people to reveal good data about themselves are employers. Data published by business networking site Viadeo in March 2007 says a fifth of recruiters look for details about prospective employees online; 25 per cent actually rejected applicants based on what they saw on their blogs or on their MySpace or Facebook profiles!

Now, the survey in question was by market